

WEEK 3 OF 4 · Body

Script 3: The Clenched Fist (Tension vs. Readiness)**Theme: Emotional and Behavioral Regulation**

Rationale: Martial artists must control their power and temper. This script uses progressive relaxation to highlight the difference between a "fight" response and a "flow" response — and teaches students that tension slows them down.

Request that students find their meditation stance. Remind students of the "out."

"We often think that to be strong, we must be tense. But in the martial arts, tension slows us down and drains our energy. We are going to explore the difference between 'tight' and 'ready.'

Settle into your stance. I invite you to bring your attention to your hands. Slowly, I want you to make tight fists. Squeeze them as hard as you safely can. Feel that tension travel up your forearms, into your shoulders, and maybe even into your neck. Notice how your breathing might have stopped or become shallow. This is the body's 'fight' reaction.

Hold it for 3, 2, 1... Now, release. Let your hands open completely. Feel the blood flow back into your fingers. Feel your shoulders drop. Notice how your breath returns to a natural rhythm. Your hands are now relaxed, but they are not weak. They are ready to move instantly. This is the state of the warrior — relaxed but alert.

Take a moment to scan your body for any other areas where you are 'making a fist' — perhaps your jaw or your stomach — and see if you can release them the same way. (Pause for 15 seconds.)

Memorize this feeling of 'relaxed readiness.' When you are ready, bring your attention back to the room and open your eyes."

MINDEFULNESS ON THE MATS